

Lab 3.2: CRM Data Entry and Networking Strategy

Introduction

In this lab, you will practice using a CRM as a relationship management tool, not just a database. You will simulate entering key information for a new account into a CRM and plan a simple and intentional networking strategy for an industry event.

The focus is on clarity, relevance, and follow-through, not software mastery. These are foundational habits that apply regardless of which CRM platform you use.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lab, you will be able to:

- Enter CRM data with outcome-focused notes that preserve context and support future engagement.
- Identify which CRM fields matter most for
- relationship continuity.
- Design a networking strategy with clear goals, target contacts, and follow-up plans.



- Log networking sources and conversation context to enable warm follow-up.
- Connect CRM practices for prospecting, account planning, and relationship management workflows.



Scenario

Your Company: ProClean Commercial Services

Event: Local Business Facility Management Association (LBFMA)
monthly meeting

Event Context:

Date: First Thursday of every month, 6:00-8:00 PM

Location: Downtown Convention Center

Typical attendance: 40-60 facility managers, operations leaders,
and vendors

Format: Networking hour (6:00-7:00), brief speaker/panel (7:00-7:30), open networking (7:30-8:00)

Attendee profile: Mix of current facility managers, aspiring professionals, and service providers (cleaning, HVAC, security, etc.)

Your Goal:

ProClean is attending to build relationships with potential new clients and identify referral partners. You want to capture contacts accurately in your CRM and plan thoughtful follow-up that creates continuity, not just collecting business cards.

New Contact You Met at the Event

Person: Jennifer Wong, Operations Manager at BrightWave Solutions

Context from conversation:

Company: BrightWave Solutions (technology consulting firm)

Industry: Professional services / technology consulting

Size: ~75 employees (grew from 50 last year)

Office: ~12,000 sq ft in downtown office building

Current situation: Using in-house part-time cleaning staff (2 employees)

Challenge mentioned: "Hard to maintain consistency as we have grown; sometimes conference rooms are not ready for client meetings."

Decision process: Jennifer manages facilities, reports to CFO (budget holder)

Timing: Not urgent, but evaluating options over next quarter

Connection point: Jennifer knows Marcus Thompson at TechStart (your existing customer)

How you met: Jennifer approached you after hearing you mention TechStart during networking.

Your Role:

You exchanged business cards and had a 10-minute conversation. Now you need to enter this contact into your CRM to ensure you follow up effectively and don't lose the context of your conversation.

Activity Steps

Exercise 1: CRM Data Entry Simulation

Step 1: Review the CRM Simulation Worksheet

The worksheet includes fields for:

- Account information (company, industry, and size)
- Contact information (name, title, email, and phone)
- Relationship source (how you met)
- Conversation notes (context from initial meeting)
- Next steps (follow-up actions with timing)

Step 2: Complete Account Information

Enter basic firmographic data for BrightWave Solutions:

Company name, industry, employee count, and office size

Account tier (A/B/C) - Use territory planning criteria: Is this a good fit? What is the potential value?

Current provider status (in-house, competitor, and no service)

Step 3: Complete Contact Information

Enter Jennifer Wong's details:

Name, title, email (jennifer.wong@brightwave.com), and phone

Stakeholder role: Operations Manager (day-to-day facilities, but CFO approves budget)

Decision influence: High operational and medium budget authority

Step 4: Log Relationship Source

Document how you met Jennifer:

Source type: Industry networking event (LBFMA).

Specific context: Jennifer approached you after hearing TechStart mention.

Referral connection: Knows Marcus Thompson at TechStart (existing customer).

Why this matters: Warm connection through mutual contact, not cold outreach.

Step 5: Write Outcome-Focused Conversation Notes

Capture the meaningful context from your conversation:

Current challenge: Consistency issues with in-house staff as the company grows.

Specific pain point: Conference rooms not ready for client meetings.

Decision process: Jennifer manages; CFO approves budget.

Timeline: Evaluating options over the next quarter (not urgent).

Key connection: Knows Marcus at TechStart, approached you based on that.

Opportunity signal: Growing company (50→75 employees) and client-facing needs.

Important: Avoid vague notes like "Good conversation" or "Interested in services." Capture specific business context that helps you (or a teammate) follow up intelligently weeks from now.

Step 6: Define Next Steps with Ownership and Timing

Document concrete follow-up actions:

What: Send email within 48 hours referencing conversation and TechStart connection.

When: By [specific date - Friday of this week].



Who: You (the account owner).

Purpose: Maintain momentum, offer to share how ProClean supports TechStart.

Additional step: Ask Marcus (TechStart) if he would be comfortable with you mentioning his positive experience to Jennifer.

Exercise 2: Networking Strategy Outline

Step 7: Draft Your Networking Strategy for LBFMA Meeting

Write a short paragraph (4-6 sentences) that outlines your approach.
Address:

Primary goal: What are you trying to accomplish?
(Build relationships, identify prospects, gather market intel, and find referral partners.)

Target contacts: Who specifically are you hoping to meet?
(Facility managers at growing companies, decision-makers, et cetera.)

Introduction approach: How will you introduce yourself and ProClean?
(Focus on value, not pitch.)

Follow-up plan: How will you ensure connections do not go cold? (CRM logging, 48-hour follow-up email, et cetera)

Step 8: Keep Your Strategy Realistic and Relationship-Focused

Avoid common networking mistakes:

- Do not try to meet everyone (focus beats breadth).

- Do not pitch immediately (build rapport first).

- Do not collect cards without context (quality over quantity).

- Do not skip CRM logging (context fades fast without documentation).

Self-Assessment Checklist

Before reviewing the exemplar solution, check whether you have:

- Included all required CRM fields, including account information, contact details, relationship source, conversation notes, and next steps.
- Recorded conversation notes that capture specific business context and customer challenges rather than generic statements.
- Defined next steps that clearly specify what needs to be done, who is responsible, and when it should happen.
- Identified Jennifer's operational role and the CFO's role in the purchasing decision.



Documented the warm connection through Marcus Thompson at TechStart.

Developed a networking strategy with a clear relationship-building goal and a specific target audience.

Used a value-focused introduction approach instead of a sales pitch.

Included a realistic follow-up plan with timely CRM logging and follow-up within 48 hours.

Summary

Congratulations! You have completed this lab. In this lab, you recorded key account and contact information in a CRM, documented meaningful conversation details and follow-up actions, and developed a relationship-focused networking strategy. These activities helped reinforce the importance of accurate CRM documentation and intentional follow-up in building long-term customer relationships.

Downloadable Resource: Lab 3.2 Exemplar Solution

Below is an example of a strong CRM data entry and networking strategy for the BrightWave Solutions scenario. This demonstrates an appropriate level of detail, outcome-focused notes, and professional networking approach.

This is one strong approach, not the only correct one. Your entries may vary based on how you prioritize information; what matters is capturing context that enables effective follow-up.

Exemplar: CRM Data Entry for BrightWave Solutions

Account Information

Company Name: BrightWave Solutions

Industry: Professional Services / Technology Consulting

Employee Count: ~75 (grew from 50 in past year)

Office Size: 12,000 sq ft

Location: Downtown office building

Current Provider: In-house part-time staff (2 employees)

Account Tier: B-tier (good fit, moderate size, and growth trajectory)

Opportunity Status: Early stage - evaluating options, not urgent

Contact Information

Name: Jennifer Wong

Title: Operations Manager

Email: jennifer.wong@brightwave.com

Phone: (805) 555-0147

Stakeholder Role: Operations lead - manages facilities day-to-day

Decision Influence: High operational authority, reports to CFO for budget approval

Reports To: CFO (budget holder - not yet engaged)

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Relationship Source

Source: LBFMA monthly networking event (Jan 2026)

How we met: Jennifer approached me after hearing me mention TechStart during networking.

Referral connection: Jennifer knows Marcus Thompson (Office Manager at TechStart - our existing customer.)

Context: Warm introduction based on mutual connection, not cold outreach.

Conversation Notes

Met Jennifer Wong (Operations Manager) at the LBFMA Jan 2026 meeting. BrightWave is a 75-employee tech consulting firm that has grown from 50 employees in the past year. Currently using 2 part-time in-house cleaning staff but experiencing consistency issues. Jennifer mentioned a specific challenge: "Conference rooms sometimes are not ready for client meetings" due to growth and scheduling conflicts with in-house staff. Decision process: Jennifer manages facilities operationally, but CFO approves budget. Timeline: Evaluating options over the next quarter, not urgent, but open to conversations. Key connection: Jennifer knows Marcus Thompson at TechStart and approached me specifically after hearing TechStart mentioned. Strong opportunity signal: growing company with client-facing facility needs and warm referral connections through existing customers.

Next Steps

Action: Send follow-up email within 48 hours (by Friday, Jan 10).

Content: Reference to LBFMA conversation, mention Marcus/TechStart connection, offer to share how we support TechStart's growth.

Owner: Me (ProClean Account Manager).

Secondary step: Check with Marcus at TechStart - would he be comfortable with me sharing his positive experience with Jennifer? (Ask during the next TechStart touchpoint).

CRM reminder: Follow up 1 week after email if there is no response.

Long-term: Add to prospecting cadence, monitor for timing signals (budget cycle and growth milestones).

Exemplar: Networking Strategy for LBFMA Meeting

My primary goal for attending the LBFMA monthly meeting is to build genuine relationships with facility managers at growing companies (50-150 employees) who might be experiencing growing pains with their current cleaning arrangements. I am specifically hoping to connect with operations managers and facility directors who manage client-facing spaces and value professional appearance. When introducing myself, I will lead with a

question about their current challenges rather than pitching ProClean immediately; something like "How are you managing facility operations as your company scales?" This creates conversation, not a sales pitch. For every meaningful connection I make, I will log the conversation in my CRM within 24 hours, capturing specific business context and pain points mentioned. I will follow up with a personalized email within 48 hours that references our specific conversation and offers value (industry insights, relevant case study, or introduction to a resource) rather than immediately asking for a meeting. The goal is relationship continuity, not transactions.

Why This Exemplar Works

CRM Entry Strengths:

Complete context: Anyone picking up this account would understand the full story.

Specific business challenge: "Conference rooms not ready" is actionable, not vague.

Decision process documented: Jennifer (operations) + CFO (budget) = know who to engage.

Warm connection noted: Marcus/TechStart relationship creates credibility.

Timeline captured: "Next quarter" sets realistic expectations, not false urgency.

Next steps have ownership and timing: "Send email by Friday" is accountable.

Account tier assigned: B-tier reflects good fit with moderate size/growth.

Networking Strategy Strengths:

Specific target profile: "50-150 employees, growing, client-facing" not "anyone"

Value-first introduction: Asks about challenges before pitching

CRM integration: Commits to logging within 24 hours

Timely follow-up: 48 hours while conversation is fresh

Offers value in follow-up: Insights/case study, not immediate sales ask

Relationship-focused: "Continuity, not transaction" mindset

Realistic scope: Build genuine relationships (quality), not collect all cards (quantity)

Course connection: This CRM entry follows the CRM Field Guide (outcome-focused notes, complete fields, and next steps with timing). The networking strategy applies relationship management principles from Account Management Playbook (earning trust before asking) and FAQ: Asking for Referrals (leverage warm connections like Marcus).

Outcome

By the end of this lab, you should have:

- A completed CRM simulation worksheet for BrightWave Solutions with all required fields.
- Outcome-focused conversation notes that preserve business context.
- Next steps documented with specific actions, timing, and ownership.
- A networking strategy paragraph (4-6 sentences) with clear goals and follow-up plan.
- Evidence of understanding: CRM as relationship memory, networking as relationship-building.

Summary

Congratulations! You have completed your first CRM data entry simulation and networking strategy. This lab reinforces that effective CRM use is not about volume; it is about preserving context for future engagement. Strong networking is not about collecting contacts; it is about building continuity.

As you continue through Module 3, you will build these CRM and networking skills by practicing referral requests, customer advocacy strategies, and long-term relationship management. The discipline you build around CRM usage and networking follow-through directly impacts your effectiveness as a sales professional.
